

Pacifism Vs Just War

prc-pacifism-vs-just-war

Christian Ethics · War & Violence · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 1.000
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Just-war and pacifist positions are both held by faithful Christians; Brethren tradition has historically leaned toward pacifism or non-combatant service while not making it absolute.

In plain language

The Greek and Hebrew put two ethics side by side and do not flatten them. In Matthew 5:39 Jesus says do not resist the evil one, using a form of the verb anthistemi under a negative, with personal examples: a slap, a lawsuit, a forced mile. In 5:44 the present-tense command keeps loving enemies. In Matthew 26:52 Jesus tells his own disciple to put the sword back, with the maxim that those who take the sword die by it. Romans 12 builds the same disciple ethic: never repay evil for evil, leave room for God's wrath, vengeance belongs to him, overcome evil with good. Read together these push toward refusing personal force. But the next sentence in Romans 13:4 calls the civil ruler God's servant who does not carry the sword, machaira, in vain, an avenger, ekdikos, who carries out wrath on the wrongdoer. Strikingly the very right Romans 12:19 takes from the believer (ekdikesis) Romans 13:4 hands to the magistrate (ekdikos), same root, different agent. Genesis 9:6 puts capital justice into human hands at creation. The Old Testament eye for eye formula is judicial language for judges, not personal revenge. John the Baptist tells soldiers to stop extorting and live on their pay but does not tell them to quit. The same letter that forbids the believer to avenge calls the state an avenger, and the canon does not say in plain words whether one believer can occupy both roles. One careful reader says the disciple must never take up lethal force and that Romans simply describes God using worldly powers. Another careful reader says force belongs to a God-given civic sphere and that Matthew governs only private revenge. A third reader holds both, accepting civil sword in principle while declining personal combatant service. Because the canon supplies real warrant for more than one reading, and the words do not rank them, the lexical pattern here is contested rather than uniform.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H5869	עַיִן	ayin	eye	
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	
H7523	רָצַח	ratsach	to murder	47
H8210	שָׁפַךְ	shaphak	to pour	117
H8478	תַּחַת	tachath	underneath	
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapao	to love	145
G0059	ἀγοράζω	agorazō	to buy	
G0436	ἀντίστημι	anthistemi	to oppose	14
G0467	ἀνταποδίδωμι	antapodidomi	to repay	7

G0473	ἀντί	anti	for	
G1249	διάκονος	diakonos	servant	33
G1286	διασεῖω	diaseiō	to extort	
G1557	ἐκδίκησις	ekdikesis	vengeance	9
G1558	ἐκδικος	ekdikos	avenging	2
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G2190	ἐχθρός	echthros	enemy	32
G2556	κακός	kakos	evil/harm	50
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambanō	to take	
G3162	μάχαιρα	machaira	sword	29
G3361	μή	mē	not	
G3404	μισέω	miseō	to hate	
G3528	νικάω	nikaō	to conquer	
G3709	ὀργή	orge	wrath	36
G3788	ὀφθαλμός	ophthalmos	eye	
G4754	στρατεύομαι	strateuō	to battle	
G5281	ὑπομονή	hupomone	perseverance	32
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hupotasso	to subject	38
G5401	φόβος	phobos	fear	47
G5411	φόρος	phoros	tax	5

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two lexically dense patterns stand in real tension and the words alone do not rank them. On one side, Matt 5:39 places the aorist active infinitive antistenai (G0436) under a prohibition addressed to the disciple in the second person, illustrated by personal insult, lawsuit, and corvee, and Matt 5:44 sets a present-imperative agapate of the echthros, while Rom 12:17-21 forbids apodidontes kakon anti kakou, reserves ekdikesis (G1557) to God, and commands nika en to agatho to kakon, and Matt 26:52 has Jesus tell the disciple apostrepson ten machairan with the warning hoi labontes machairan en machaira apolountai. On the other side, the same epistle one sentence later (Rom 13:4) calls the ruler theou diakonos who ou eike ten machairan (G3162) phorei as an ekdikos (G1558) eis orgen, with cognate antitassomai and the perfect anthesteken in 13:2 turning culpable a structurally identical anti-stem in the civil sphere. The OT lex talionis (Exod 21:24, Lev 24:20, Deut 19:21) is judicial not personal, and Gen 9:6 grounds civic capital justice in the image of God. The canon supplies both a non-retaliatory disciple ethic and a sanctioned civil sword, and the lemmas do not adjudicate whether the same person occupies both roles.

Scripture

Matt.5.38 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3788 ὀφθαλμός, G0473 ἀντί

Force. Ophthalmon anti ophthalmou kai odonta anti odontos quotes the OT lex talionis (Exod 21:24, Lev 24:20, Deut 19:21). In its OT setting the formula is judicial, given to magistrates as a proportional ceiling on civic punishment, not as a license for personal payback. Reading the citation against its OT source clarifies that Jesus is not abrogating civic justice but addressing the disciple's personal posture, which is what the following verses unfold.

Matt.5.39 · for · genre: gospel · figures: hyperbole

Key terms. G0436 ἀντίστημι, G3361 μή

Force. The prohibition me antistenai to ponero uses the aorist active infinitive of anthistemi under the negative me, governing the disciple addressed in the second person. The grammar pairs with the dative articular to ponero, which can mean the evil one or the evil person. The four illustrations that follow are personal and sub-lethal: the right cheek slap, the chiton in court, the compelled mile, the borrower. The clause constrains personal retaliation. Whether it extends to the magistrate or to lethal force is left open by the grammar itself.

Matt.5.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω, G2190 ἐχθρός

Force. The present imperative agapate tous echthrous hymon commands ongoing love of enemies, reversing the cited mishesis ton echthron. The construction is durative not punctiliar, and the object is plural and personal. A non-resistant reading takes this as a kingdom ethic that excludes lethal response from the disciple, a sphere-distinction reading takes it as compatible with restraining a violent neighbor for the protection of the third party. The lemma does not by itself adjudicate the use of force by ordained authority.

Matt.26.52 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3162 μάχαιρα, G2983 λαμβάνω

Force. Apostrepson ten machairan sou eis ton topon autes, pantes gar hoi labontes machairan en machaira apolountai is Jesus's own constraint on disciple sword use at the moment force is offered in his defense. The aorist active imperative apostrepson and the gnomic apolountai express a standing maxim about who lives by the sword. The grammar weighs against a disciple deploying lethal force in the kingdom's name, although the maxim is general enough that a sphere-distinction reading restricts it to private vigilantism.

Rom.12.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0467 ἀνταποδίδωμι, G2556 κακός

Force. Medeni kakon anti kakou apodidontes, with the present participle apodidontes negated by medeni, frames a categorical disciple ethic of non-recompense in kind. The cognate anti structure echoes Matt 5:38 lex talionis but inverts it for personal conduct. This verse begins the pivot that runs into Rom 13 and is the literary hinge the canon places between the non-retaliatory disciple ethic and the civil sword.

Rom.12.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1557 ἐκδίκησις, G3709 ὀργή

Force. Me heautous ekdikountes, agapetoi, alla dote topon te orge. Gegraptai gar, emoi ekdikesis, ego antapodoso, legei Kurios. The middle participle ekdikountes is forbidden to the disciple, ekdikesis is reserved to God, and orge is given its proper object. Crucially the same root ekdik- reappears as ekdikos in Rom 13:4, transferred onto the civil ruler, so the canon takes the very right that 12:19 withholds from the believer and locates it in the state. This is the lexical pivot that holds both poles together and forbids collapsing either one.

Rom.12.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3528 νικάω, G0018 ἀγαθός

Force. Me niko hupo tou kakou, alla nika en to agatho to kakon. Present imperatives with hupo of agency and en of instrument frame the disciple's victory as moral, accomplished by good not force. This caps the personal ethic block immediately before the civil sphere appears in 13:1.

Rom.13.1 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G1849 ἐξουσία

Force. Pasa psyche exousiais hyperechousais hupotassestho, with the present passive imperative hupotassestho and the universal pasa psyche, places every soul under the exousiai. The clause hai de ousai hypo theou tetagmenai eisin uses the perfect passive tetagmenai to assert a settled, prior ordering by God. The grammar leaves no creaturely sphere where exousia is not under God's order, although it does not specify the believer's mode of participation.

Rom.13.2 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0436 ἀνθίστημι, G1849 ἐξουσία

Force. Ho antitassomenos te exousia te tou theou diatage anthesteken, with the perfect anthesteken and the participle anthestekotes, declares that resisting the authority resists God's ordinance and incurs krima. The same anti-stem family that Matt 5:39 prohibits in personal retaliation here describes culpable resistance to the governing power, and the shift in object (personal evildoer vs ordained authority) is the structural heart of the canonical tension.

Rom.13.4 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3162 μάχαιρα, G1249 διάκονος, G1558 ἑκδικός

Force. The ruler is twice called theou diakonos and is said to bear the machaira: ou gar eike ten machairan phorei, theou gar diakonos estin, ekdikos eis orgen to katechorounti to kakon prassonti. Eike (in vain) plus the present phorei (carries habitually) frames the sword as a real, ongoing instrument of office, not metaphor. The noun ekdikos is the cognate of the very ekdikesis denied to the believer in 12:19, so the same right is here vested in the civil officer. The text grounds a sphere where coercive force is divinely authorized, which materially complicates an absolute pacifist reading.

Luke.22.36 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3162 μάχαιρα, G0059 ἀγοράζω

Force. Ho me echon agorasato... machairan instructs the one without a sword to buy one. The aorist imperative agorasato is grammatically a real command, yet the disciples' production of two and Jesus's abrupt hikanon estin in 22:38, plus the rebuke at the arrest in 22:51 and Matt 26:52, pull against reading it as a standing mandate for armed force. The grammar permits both a literal and a figurative provisioning reading, and the saying is invoked by both sides without lexically resolving either.

Luke.3.14 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4754 στρατεύομαι, G1286 διασείω

Force. Strateuomenoi ask ti poiesomen kai hemeis, and John answers medena diaseisete mede sykophantesete, kai arkeisthe tois opsoniois hymon. The participle strateuomenoi is left intact, the prohibitions target extortion and intimidation, and opsoniois names the soldier's wage. The grammar regulates how a soldier conducts himself, it does not require him to leave the office. This is one of the strongest NT data points for a continuing legitimacy of military vocation, although it does not by itself authorize the believer's participation.

Gen.9.6 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H8210 שָׁפַךְ, H6754 צָלַם

Force. Shophek dam ha'adam ba'adam damo yishaphek, ki betselem Elohim asah et-ha'adam. The participial shophek (shedder) is set against the passive yishaphek (his blood shall be shed), with the agent ba'adam (by man) explicit. The grounding clause ki betselem Elohim ties capital justice to the imago Dei. This places lethal civil sanction at the post-flood foundation of human community, prior to Israel and Sinai, which is why Rom 13:4 can claim creational warrant for the sword.

Exod.21.24 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. H5869 עֵין, H8478 תַּחַת

Force. Ayin tachat ayin, shen tachat shen, yad tachat yad, regel tachat regel. The preposition tachat (under, in place of) sets the formula in a judicial code (mishpatim) administered by judges, not in a private revenge code. Read in source context this is a proportional ceiling on civic punishment, which is exactly what Jesus's citation in Matt 5:38 invokes before he addresses personal posture.

Rev.13.10 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G3162 μάχαιρα, G5281 ὑπομονή

Force. Ei tis en machaira apoktanthenai, auton en machaira apoktanthenai. Hode estin he hypomone kai he pistis ton hagion. The conditional construction and the closing hypomone of the saints locate the church's posture under empire in patient endurance, not armed resistance. The verse reinforces Matt 26:52 for the gathered church, without removing Rom 13:4 from the civil sphere.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.13.4	Rom.12.19	tsk	2
Rom.13.4	Gen.9.6	openbible	1
Rom.13.4	Prov.16.14	tsk	1
Rom.12.19	Deut.32.35	tsk	2
Matt.5.39	Lev.19.18	tsk	1
Matt.5.38	Exod.21.24	tsk	1
Matt.5.38	Lev.24.20	tsk	1
Matt.5.38	Deut.19.21	tsk	1
Matt.5.44	Exod.23.4	tsk	1
Matt.5.44	Prov.25.21	tsk	1
Matt.26.52	Gen.9.6	openbible	1
Rom.13.1	Deut.17.12	tsk	1
Rom.13.1	1Pet.2.13	openbible	2
Luke.3.14	Acts.10.1	openbible	1
Rev.13.10	Matt.26.52	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Rom.13.4 · addressed

The state's bearing of the machaira as theou diakonos and ekdikos eis orgen establishes a divinely sanctioned sphere of coercive force. Addressed by noting the sphere distinction in the immediate context: Rom 12:19 explicitly forbids the believer to perform ekdikesis and reserves it to God, then 13:4 calls the civil officer ekdikos. The cognate root carries the same right from one agent to another within the same paragraph. The texts are not formally contradictory but locate force in different agents. The distinction does not by itself settle whether a believer may serve as that agent, which is exactly where the readings diverge.

Luke.22.36 · addressed

The imperative agorasato machairan is read alongside hikanon estin in 22:38, Jesus's apostrepson ten machairan and the gnomic in Matt 26:52, and the rebuke of sword use at the arrest in Luke 22:51. Addressed by treating the saying as a vivid signal of impending hostility plus a literary setup for the en anomois elogisthe quotation in 22:37, since the immediate two swords are called enough and lethal use is checked moments later. The grammar permits both a literal and a figurative provisioning reading, so it weakens rather than resolves either position.

Rom.13.2 · addressed

The perfect anthesteken applied to resisting the exousia uses the same anti-stem family that Matt 5:39 prohibits in personal retaliation. Addressed by observing the different objects of the verb: in Rom 13:2 the object is God's ordained authority, in Matt 5:39 it is the personal evildoer. The shared root across opposite relations is acknowledged as the structural reason the canon does not yield a single uncontested verdict.

Luke.3.14 · addressed

John's instruction to strateuomenoi regulates conduct without requiring exit from the office, and Acts 10 narrates a centurion received without rebuke of vocation. Addressed by noting that the imperative content (no diaseio, no sykophanteo, contentment with opsonion) targets abuse of military power, not the office itself. The non-rebuke is a real signal but it is an argument from silence about the office, not an explicit endorsement of lethal force by the believer.

Matt.26.52 · addressed

Hoi labontes machairan en machaira apolountai is gnomic and stops the disciple's defensive use of force at the cost of Jesus's mission. Addressed by reading it under that immediate context, which a non-resistant reader extends to all disciples and a sphere-distinction reader restricts to private vigilantism that pre-empts magistrate authority. The grammar does not specify the scope.

Concordance traversed

G0436, G3162, G1849, G1249, G1558, G1557, G2190, G0025, G0467, G2556, G3709, G5293, G5411, G5401, G5281, G0473, G3404, H7523, H8210

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied for the cited verses and the bundle marks not_in_ecm_scope true. The SBLGNT marginal sigla in Matt 5:39, 5:44, Matt 26:52, Luke 22:36-38, Rom 12:19-21 and Rom 13:1-4 touch word order, minor pronoun forms, and the presence or absence of articular constructions, but they do not alter the presence of antisthenai, machaira, ekdikesis, ekdikos, agapate, or the love-of-enemies imperative. The verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. two_kingdoms_sphere_distinction, sermon_on_the_mount_kingdom_ethic, creational_civil_order_genesis_9, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology, anabaptist_non_resistance

analogia scripturae invoked

personal_non_resistance_lens: leans pacifist · Reads me antistenai to ponero in Matt 5:39, the present imperative agapate tous echthrous in 5:44, the gnomie hoi labontes machairan en machaira apolountai in Matt 26:52, and the Rom 12:17-21 sequence forbidding kakon anti kakou and reserving ekdikesis to God as a binding kingdom ethic for the disciple. Rom 13 is read as descriptive of God's use of civil powers and not as a mandate the believer may personally execute. Rev 13:10 hypomone is taken as the church's standing posture.

sphere_distinction_just_war_lens: leans just-war · Reads Rom 13:4, the ruler bearing the machaira as theou diakonos and ekdikos eis orgen, with cognate weight from Rom 12:19, as establishing a legitimate sphere of coercive justice that Gen 9:6 grounds at creation prior to Israel. Limits Matt 5:39 to private retaliation by attending to the sub-lethal personal examples and the second-person address, treats Luke 3:14 and the unrebuked centurion vocation (Acts 10) as continuity of military office, and reads Matt 26:52 as a maxim against private vigilantism that pre-empts magistrate authority. Concludes a believer may participate in restraining evil through ordained authority.

vocational_dualism_lens: middle_position · Reads the personal commands as binding on the disciple in private capacity and the Rom 13 sword as binding on civic office, but treats the believer as living in both spheres with different ethics in each, so non-combatant service or restricted participation is the consistent application. The lemmas support sphere distinction without specifying overlap.

canonical_tension_lens: disputed · Holds that the anti-stem appearing in Matt 5:39 and Rom 13:2, the ekdik- root traveling from Rom 12:19 to Rom 13:4, the machaira appearing in Rom 13:4, Luke 22:36, Matt 26:52, and Rev 13:10, and Gen 9:6 sitting under Rom 13:4, yield genuinely competing emphases that morphology alone does not reconcile. Faithful readers reach different defensible conclusions and the lexical pattern is materially contested.

The verdict turns on whether the second-person prohibition in Matt 5:39 and the disciple ethic of Rom 12:17-21 govern only personal retaliation or a comprehensive ethic for the believer in every role, and on whether the same person may bear the machaira described in Rom 13:4. analogia_scripturae is invoked because the readings differ precisely in how they harmonize personal disciple instructions with civil office instructions inside one canon.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition does not preload a single verdict on the lexical question of force, since it explicitly affirms that both just-war and pacifist positions are held by faithful readers, which matches the contested lexical pattern. The embedded clause about a community having historically leaned toward pacifism or non-combatant service is a sociological claim about a community that the lexical store cannot confirm or deny, so it is set aside. The verdict was derived only on the lexical question of whether the canon yields a single uncontested position on the believer and force.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.5.39
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.13.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.13.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.12.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.26.52
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.9.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.21.24
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0436
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3162
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1849
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1558

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1557
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8210
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.12.19
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.13.4
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Luke.22.36
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.9.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.13.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.5.39
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.12.19
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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent